

Dark zone

Three thousand three hundred feet (1,000 m) below the ocean surface, the faint blue glow of the twilight zone fades out completely. Here, the only light is made by animals equipped with luminous organs of their own. Many of these are extraordinary-looking hunters with a variety of amazing adaptations for finding, catching, and eating their scarce prey.

DEATHTRAP

In the darkness of the deep, some fish are attracted to light. The deep-sea anglerfish makes use of this by holding a glowing lure in front of its enormous mouth.

Any fish that comes close to investigate the glow risks being seized and swallowed whole.

Sharp, curved teeth stop prey from escaping

Lure is suspended on a stout spine, and glows with blue light produced by bacteria

Long, whiplike tail

Dark body makes the anglerfish hard to see, even in the light of its lure

SEARCHLIGHT

Some predators, such as the stoplight loosejaw fish, have red searchlights for targeting their prey in the dark. Since most deep-sea animals cannot see red light, they do not know they are being stalked until it is too late.

The red searchlights are most effective at revealing red-colored animals that would be invisible if lit up by the blue light produced by other deep-sea animals.

▲ RED PRAWN

To escape from the spotlight loosejaw fish, a deep-sea red prawn releases luminous fluid to confuse its enemy.

Luminous fluid

Light organs are located beneath the eyes

Long, needle-sharp teeth give the fish a deadly grip